

apply. Whether you're the one in charge of planning or asking questions of the planner, it's uncomfortable at first. But asking all involved something along the lines of "What is everyone comfortable contributing?" Or "I'm able to contribute \$50. Beyond the money, are there any other ways I can help with this event?" Being honest about your own capacity will help bring definition to the plans and inevitably decrease anxiety for all! Remember that getting hit with a Venmo request for an absurd amount of money after the celebrations are over is way worse than communicating about costs up front.

And now we're going to share an unpopular, spicy opinion. Brace yourself. It's also possible you choose to limit your participation in an event, even in cases where full participation is expected of you. If up-front communication about money reveals that it's outside of the scope of what's okay for you, kindly decline or offer alternatives. At different seasons of life, there have been times I (Jill) chose not to be a bridesmaid or not host an event. There have also been seasons when I gladly spearheaded the baby shower and attended the destination wedding. It's not about being stingy and always saying no, it's about saying a noncompulsory, intentional yes with eyes wide open to what you're agreeing to.

Our true friends, the ones who have our back, do not want us to harm ourselves in efforts of support to them.

With Our Coworkers and Acquaintances

Our friend Sarah works in a really tight-knit dental office that has regular, themed dress-up days. From St. Patrick's Day to Halloween, there's always a reason for wearing themed clothing, hats, and funky glasses. Sarah has described really enjoying the environment she works in but admitted that she spends at least \$50 each month buying the matching stuff or bringing in the fun food. Money she would prefer to put toward her debt payoff. Saying no to any of it feels especially difficult because she sees these people every day. And she does actually like them!

The relational expectations with our coworkers and acquaintances may not be high, but the pressure to spend and the demands for our money are still present. From gifts for coworkers' birthdays to happy hours and